

FALL 2026
RWS 305W, A1 (12690)

COURSE INFORMATION

Class Days: Tuesday
Class Time: 2:00 – 3:15
Class Location: LH 247

Instructor: Matt Feigner
Email: mfeigner@sdsu.edu
Office location: [Zoom](#)
Office hours: Thursdays,
4:00 PM - 6:40 PM and by
appointment

CREDITS AND PREREQUISITES

Credits	3 Credit hours
Prerequisites	Completion of 60 units and completion of General Education requirements in Communication and Critical Thinking
Class Standing	Junior, Senior, Graduate

COURSE REQUIREMENTS

Required	N/A
Recommended	N/A

Canvas LMS and Technology Requirements

All materials are accessed through Canvas.

Computer access is required for Canvas posts, Internet links and assignment submissions.

You may use a mobile device for most aspects of our course, but these devices are not always user friendly with Canvas, especially assignment submissions.

COURSE DESCRIPTION

Successful completion of RWS 305W satisfies the Graduation Writing Assessment Requirement (GWAR) for students who have met the prerequisites noted below. Rhetoric and Writing Studies 305W is designed to help upper-level students develop the communication skills needed for

successful professional careers. The course builds on the rhetorical model that students are introduced to in earlier 100 and 200-level courses: attention to audience, purpose, presentation (genre and organization), evidence, and language

STUDENT LEARNING OUTCOMES

In RWS 305W students learn to respond not just to academic tasks but a wider variety of genres and settings that require diverse research methods and writing styles. The course also asks students to reflect on and evaluate the effectiveness of their own writing style(s) within rhetorical contexts.

- Analyze and evaluate complex print, digital, and multimodal texts that engage significant academic, professional, or civic issues.
- Apply rhetorical principles appropriate to different purposes and goals, within specific disciplinary, professional and civic communities.
- Research and contribute to specific areas of inquiry by evaluating, synthesizing, and integrating strategies and sources appropriate to genre.
- Adapt and employ conventions to communicate with diverse audiences who are members of or affected by a specific area or discipline.
- Compose a variety of texts, working individually and collaboratively, through processes of drafting, critiquing, reflecting, and editing.

ASSIGNMENT AND ASSESSMENT METHODS

The course consists of four major projects arranged in modules, each responding to a different rhetorical situation. Within each module, a revised final draft of the project culminates from a series of assignments, including reflection-oriented journal entries that are informed by the module readings, recorded video sessions, and working (rough) drafts. Point values for assignments are based on the instructor's judgment of the overall quality of submitted coursework as evaluated against a set of published criteria. Due dates, module details and submission instructions for all work are in the course assignment schedule on Canvas. Due dates are critical; all work is carefully sequenced to maximize your learning and to facilitate completion of the Course Learning Outcomes. To be successful, students must assume a high level of self-discipline and

responsibility for meeting all deadlines. Late submissions may not receive points.

The project components and points associated with them are listed in the table below.

Module	Assignment	Points	Total
Introductory Module: Required First Step	Syllabus & Policy Acknowledgment	10	10
Module 1: Career Portfolio	1. Reflection & Direction Journal 2. Cover Letter 3. Resume (Both the resume and cover letter may be revised for the possibility of a higher grade.)	50 100 100	250
Module 2: Labor Market Analysis Report	1. Reflection & Direction Journal (2 entries) 2. Quiz: Plagiarism & Paraphrasing 3. Labor Market Report (not able to be revised for higher grade)	40 10 200	250
Module 3: Rhetorical Analysis Paper	1. Three Chapter Quizzes 2. Reflection & Direction Journal 3. Narrated Presentation and script (not able to be revised for a higher grade)	60 30 200	290
Public Voice Project	Public Discourse Project or Future Retirement Speech	200	200
Course Total			1000

ASSIGNMENT DESCRIPTIONS

There are four major projects in this class, along with a number of smaller assignments intended to enhance your understanding of the course materials and content. Below are brief descriptions of these assignments.

- **Introductory Module: Syllabus and Policy Acknowledgment**
The initial assignment familiarizes you with course goals and guidelines. Note that by submitting this acknowledgement, you agree to honor all course policies.
- **Project 1: Career Portfolio**
This module has three parts: a resume, a cover letter—both written in response to a current job announcement—and a reflection on career-related readings that will aid in writing your resume and cover letter, and in applying for future jobs and internships.
- **Project 2: Labor Market Analysis Report**
This module includes a major project: the Labor Market Analysis Report. It also has an online quiz on plagiarism and paraphrasing, and two reflections—one on your strengths and one on areas for improvement. For the Labor Market Analysis, you will research the skills, knowledge, and training needed for your future career, as well as future salary and employment projections.
- **Project 3: Public Discourse Project**
This module includes three chapter quizzes, a reflection, and a rhetorical analysis paper. You will read Meg Jay’s “Identity Capital,” “My Life Should Look Better on Facebook,” and “Weak Ties.” The quizzes are designed to hold you accountable for the readings before you write. The paper asks you to analyze an author’s argument, rhetorical strategies, appeals, assumptions, and persuasiveness within a specific rhetorical context.
- **Project 4: Public Voice Project**
For the final project, you will choose one of two options: the Public Discourse Project or the Future Retirement Speech. Both options ask you to use course materials to address an audience beyond this class. The Public Discourse Project asks you to advise entering SDSU

students about a major, career field, and preparation for future employability. The Future Retirement Speech asks you to speak from the point of view of your future self at the end of a career or major professional chapter.

COURSE GRADING

Course grades will be assigned according to the following distribution of points:

$> 933 = A$	$900 - 922.9 = A-$	$877.6 - 899.9 = B+$
$830 - 87.5 = B$	$800 - 822.9 = B-$	$777.6 - 799.9 = C+$
$730 - 77.5 = C$	$700 - 722.9 = C-$	$677.6 - 699.9 = D+$
$630 - 67.5 = D$	$600 - 622.9 = D-$	$< 600 = F$

Course grades will be based on points earned and assigned according to the following scale:

A	Outstanding achievement; available only for the highest accomplishment
B	Praiseworthy achievement; definitely above average
C	Average; awarded for satisfactory performance; the most common undergraduate degree
D	Minimally passing; less than the typical undergraduate achievement
F	Failing

GOOGLE DOC POLICY

All work for every assignment in this course must be completed entirely within a single Google Document created specifically for that assignment. You are required to give mfeigner@sdsu.edu full Editor access to this document from the moment it is created.

- Each assignment (cover letter, resume, reflection, Labor Market Analysis Report, Rhetorical Analysis, presentation script, etc.) requires its own separate Google Doc.
- All research, drafting, revising, editing, thinking, and development of the assignment must take place exclusively inside this one document.
- Using multiple Google Docs for the same assignment is prohibited.
- All submissions must be made by sharing the single, complete Google Doc with Editor access to the submission link on Canvas.

Please note that failure to follow any part of this policy will result in an automatic zero (0) on the assignment. This grade is final and non-negotiable. No revisions or make-up opportunities will be allowed for violations.

By submitting work in this course, you acknowledge and agree to comply with this policy.

COMMUNICATION AND FEEDBACK

Please follow these protocols for optimal communication:

- Check Canvas announcements daily.
- Use email for individual, personal matters. Email me directly at mfeigner@sdsu.edu or use the Canvas messaging tool. I will respond to your messages as soon as I can, usually in less than 24 hours.
- Check the course assignment schedule, syllabus, and **FAQs** for any questions about assignments, procedures, and policies **before emailing me**. This saves time for both of us if your question has already been addressed. For current assignments, read the supporting documents or watch the video recordings to see if your concern is covered. If you still can't find the answer, **then** email me.
- Come to office hours: I am happy to discuss any questions or concerns you have about the course or assignments or anything else for the matter.
- Review the feedback I leave directly on your documents using the Canvas grade review and feedback functions. My frank commentary should help you to see areas for improvement.
- Notify me of special circumstances: If serious illness or personal catastrophe threatens to compromise your ability to meet course criteria, please let me know in a timely manner. Usually, adjustments can be made and solutions can be reached, unless you wait too long to deal with your situation

COURSE AND UNIVERSITY POLICIES

Accommodations: If you are a student with a disability and are in need of accommodations for this class, please contact Student Ability Success Center at (619) 594-6473 as soon as possible. Please know accommodations are not retroactive, and I cannot provide accommodations based upon disability until I have received an accommodation letter from Student Ability Success Center.

Student Privacy and Intellectual Property: The [Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act](#) (FERPA) mandates the protection of student information, including contact information, grades, and graded assignments. I will use Canvas to communicate with you, and I will not post grades or leave graded assignments in public places. Students will be notified at the time of an assignment if copies of student work will be

retained beyond the end of the semester or used as examples for future students or the wider public. Students maintain intellectual property rights to work products they create as part of this course unless they are formally notified otherwise.

Religious observances: According to the University Policy File, students should notify the instructors of affected courses of planned absences for religious observances by the end of the second week of classes.

Academic Honesty: The University prohibits cheating and plagiarism.

Examples of academic dishonesty include but are not limited to:

- copying, in part or in whole, from another's test or other examination;
- obtaining copies of a test, an examination, or other course material without the permission of the instructor;
- collaborating with another or others in work to be presented without the permission of the instructor;
- falsifying records, laboratory work, or other course data;
- submitting work previously presented in another course, if contrary to the rules of the course;
- altering or interfering with grading procedures;
- assisting another student in any of the above; using sources verbatim or paraphrasing without giving proper attribution (this can include phrases, sentences, paragraphs and/or pages of work);
- copying and pasting work from an online or offline source directly and calling it your own;
- using information you find from an online or offline source without giving the author credit;
- replacing words or phrases from another source and inserting your own words or phrases.

AI-GENERATED CONTENT POLICY

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is defined, for the purpose of this course, as any computer system or program that simulates, substitutes, and/or enhances problem-solving that typically requires human intelligence. While students may use simple AI, resembling built-in features of a word processor like spelling and simple grammar checks, they are *not* permitted to use Generative AI at any stage of completing work (graded or ungraded). Generative AI is defined here as AI which has the capacity to ideate, summarize, generate, rewrite, or validate

content; including, but not limited to, tools such as ChatGPT, Bard, and DALL-E.

To be clear, using AI tools (ChatGPT, Dall-E, Grammarly, Chegg, etc.) to create or aggregate content, including:

- Course writing
- Reflective writing
- Substituting or impersonating you in any class activity

is considered academic misconduct similar to plagiarism or violations of the honor code.

* Students may formally request, in writing, an exception to the above. Such requests must include: (1) which assignment the student is requesting to use AI with, (2) which specific AI tool the student wishes to use, (3) what they plan to use the tool for (e.g., to generate ideas, summarize a longer document, create a visual, etc.), and (4) why, specifically, they are requesting the exception (e.g., to reduce time spent on a tedious task, to identify relevant sources for further investigation, etc.). Requests will be considered on a case-by-case basis.

The California State University system requires instructors to report all instances of academic misconduct to the Center for Student Rights and Responsibilities. Academic dishonesty will result in disciplinary review by the University and may lead to probation, suspension, or expulsion. Instructors may also, at their discretion, penalize student grades on any assignment or assessment discovered to have been produced in an academically dishonest manner.

Resources for students: A complete list of all academic support services--including the [Writing Center](#) and [Math Learning Center](#)--is available on the Student Affairs' [Academic Success](#) website. [Counseling and Psychological Services](#) (619-594-5220) offers confidential counseling services by licensed therapists; you can Live Chat with a counselor at http://go.sdsu.edu/student_affairs/cps/therapist-consultation.aspx between 4:00pm and 10:00pm, or call San Diego Access and Crisis 24-hour Hotline at (888) 724-7240.

Sexual violence / Title IX mandated reporting: As an instructor, one of my responsibilities is to help create a safe learning environment on our

campus. I am a mandated reporter in my role as an SDSU employee. It is my goal that you feel able to share information related to your life experiences in classroom discussions, in your written work, and in our one-on-one meetings. I will seek to keep the information you share private to the greatest extent possible. However, I am required to share information regarding sexual violence on SDSU's campus with the Title IX coordinator, Jessica Rentto 619-594-6017. She (or her designee) will contact you to let you know about accommodations and support services at SDSU and possibilities for holding accountable the person who harmed you. Know that you will not be forced to share information you do not wish to disclose and your level of involvement will be your choice. If you do not want the Title IX Officer notified, instead of disclosing this information to your instructor, you can speak confidentially with the following people on campus and in the community. They can connect you with support services and discuss options for pursuing a University or criminal investigation. Sexual Violence Victim Advocate 619-594-0210 or Counseling and Psychological Services 619-594-5220, psycserv@sdsu.edu. For more information regarding your university rights and options as a survivor of sexual misconduct or sexual violence, please visit titleix.sdsu.edu or sdsutalks.sdsu.edu.

Classroom Conduct Standards: SDSU students are expected to abide by the terms of the Student Conduct Code in classrooms and other instructional settings. Prohibited conduct includes:

- Willful, material and substantial disruption or obstruction of a University-related activity, or any on-campus activity.
- Participating in an activity that substantially and materially disrupts the normal operations of the University or infringes on the rights of members of the University community.
- Unauthorized recording, dissemination, or publication (including on websites or social media) of lectures or other course materials.
- Conduct that threatens or endangers the health or safety of any person within or related to the University community, including
 1. physical abuse, threats, intimidation, or harassment.
 2. sexual misconduct.

Violation of these standards will result in referral to appropriate campus authorities.

Medical-related absences: Students are instructed to contact their professor/instructor/coach in the event they need to miss class, etc. due to an illness, injury or emergency. All decisions about the impact of an absence, as well as any arrangements for making up work, rest with the

instructors. [Student Health Services](#) (SHS) does not provide medical excuses for short-term absences due to illness or injury. When a medical-related absence persists beyond five days, SHS will work with students to provide appropriate documentation. When a student is hospitalized or has a serious, ongoing illness or injury, SHS will, at the student's request and with the student's consent, communicate with the student's instructors via the Vice President for Student Affairs and may communicate with the student's Assistant Dean and/or the [Student Ability Success Center](#).

SDSU Economic Crisis Response Team: If you or a friend are experiencing food or housing insecurity, or any unforeseen financial crisis, visit sdsu.edu/ecrt, email ecrt@sdsu.edu, or walk-in to Well-being & Health Promotion on the 3rd floor of Calpulli Center.

Suggested: Include information about and encourage students to utilize supplemental instruction, tutoring, or other academic support resources provided by your academic unit.

SCHEDULE

WEEK OF	TOPIC	ASSIGNMENTS AND DUE DATES
8/24	Introduction to the course Principles of reader-sensitive communication	DUE: 8/28: Syllabus and Course Policy Acknowledgment Homework: 1. View the Overview of the Course video on Canvas. 2. Read the course syllabus and FAQs. 3. Complete and submit the Syllabus and Course Policy Acknowledgment. 4. Watch/read resume and cover letter guidance on Canvas. 5. Find a current job or internship announcement and save it as a PDF. 6. Begin working on the Project 1 reflection video, resume, and cover letter for a specific job or internship.
8/31	Career Portfolio Project	Homework: 1. Review resume types and templates. 2. Draft the resume contact information, profile/objective, education section, and experience sections. 3. Review Effective Experience Sections Part I and Part II on Canvas. 4. Review cover letter guidance and begin drafting the cover letter. 5. Continue working on the Project 1 reflection video.

WEEK OF	TOPIC	ASSIGNMENTS AND DUE DATES
9/7 Labor Day Rosh Hashanah (9/12-9/13)	Career Portfolio Project	DUE: 9/13: Reflection Video; Resume, Cover Letter, and Job Announcement Homework: 1. Complete the resume. 2. Complete the cover letter. 3. Complete the Project 1 reflection video and submit the YouTube link in Canvas. 4. Submit the resume, cover letter, and job announcement according to the assignment instructions.
9/14	Labor Market Analysis Project	Homework: 1. Read the Labor Market Analysis Report prompt and review the examples on Canvas. 2. View the recorded video lectures on the Labor Market Analysis Report. 3. Research your desired career field using the Bureau of Labor Statistics and other credible sources. 4. Begin working on the Reflection and Direction Journal entries on strengths and weaknesses. 5. Begin working on the plagiarism/paraphrasing quiz. 6. You may revise your resume and cover letter for the possibility of a higher grade. The higher of the two grades will count in the final course grade calculation.

WEEK OF	TOPIC	ASSIGNMENTS AND DUE DATES
9/21 Yom Kippur	Labor Market Analysis Project	DUE: 9/27: Reflection Journals: Strengths and Weaknesses; Plagiarism/Paraphrasing Quiz Homework: 1. Continue researching the desired career field. 2. Begin drafting the major report sections of the Labor Market Analysis Report. 3. Paraphrase source material carefully and document source information as you work. 4. Review visual integration and formatting rules. 5. Decide which visuals you will create to illustrate data in the report. 6. Continue revising the resume and cover letter as needed.
9/28	Labor Market Analysis Project	DUE: 10/4: Labor Market Analysis Report Homework: 1. Complete the major report sections of the Labor Market Analysis Report. 2. Integrate visuals, including titles and captions. 3. Introduce each visual before it appears and explain its significance in the text. 4. Adapt the strengths and weaknesses reflections into the conclusion and growth plan. 5. Format and polish the report according to the assignment specifications.

WEEK OF	TOPIC	ASSIGNMENTS AND DUE DATES
10/5	Intro to Rhetorical Analysis	Homework: 1. Read the Rhetorical Analysis Paper prompt and guidance on Canvas. 2. View supplementary support videos for the Rhetorical Analysis Paper. 3. Review the rhetoric/argument framework from the module. 4. Begin reading Meg Jay, "Identity Capital." 5. Begin taking notes on rhetorical situation, central argument, sub-claims, strategies, assumptions, and appeals.
10/12 Columbus Day	Rhetorical Analysis	DUE: 10/18: "Identity Capital" Quiz Homework: 1. Read Meg Jay, "Identity Capital." 2. Complete the "Identity Capital" quiz. 3. Identify the chapter's central argument and rhetorical situation. 4. Take notes on major sub-claims, assumptions, and strategies. 5. Begin thinking about which chapter you may want to analyze for the paper.
10/19	Rhetorical Analysis	DUE: 10/25: "My Life Should Look Better on Facebook" Quiz Homework: 1. Read Meg Jay, "My Life Should Look Better on Facebook." 2. Complete the chapter quiz. 3. Continue practicing rhetorical analysis of sub-claims, strategies, assumptions, warrants, audience, and appeals. 4. Begin drafting notes for the introduction and body paragraphs of the Rhetorical Analysis Paper.

WEEK OF	TOPIC	ASSIGNMENTS AND DUE DATES
10/26 Halloween Daylight Saving Time (11/1)	Rhetorical Analysis	DUE: 11/1: "Weak Ties" Quiz Homework: 1. Read Meg Jay, "Weak Ties." 2. Complete the chapter quiz. 3. Choose the chapter you will analyze for the Rhetorical Analysis Paper. 4. Draft the introduction and at least two body paragraphs. 5. Work on the Reflection and Direction Journal for Project 3.
11/2 Day of the Dead	Rhetorical Analysis	DUE: 11/8: Reflection and Direction Journal; Rhetorical Analysis Paper; Resume and Cover Letter Revisions Homework: 1. Continue drafting and revising the Rhetorical Analysis Paper. 2. Make sure the paper explains the author's argument, analyzes strategies and appeals, discusses assumptions, and evaluates persuasiveness. 3. Complete the Reflection and Direction Journal. 4. Submit final resume and cover letter revisions if you choose to revise them.
11/9 Veterans Day (11/11)	Public Voice Project	Homework: 1. Read the Public Voice Project prompt on Canvas. 2. Choose one option: Public Discourse Project or Future Retirement Speech. 3. Review relevant materials from Projects 1-3. 4. Begin planning the presentation, script, or speech. 5. Identify the audience, purpose, course materials, and main points for the project.

WEEK OF	TOPIC	ASSIGNMENTS AND DUE DATES
11/16	Public Voice Project	Homework: 1. Draft the PowerPoint script or retirement speech script. 2. Develop slides if you are completing the Public Discourse Project. 3. Plan the recording approach if you are completing the Future Retirement Speech. 4. Use course materials from the semester to support the project. 5. Continue revising the script, slides, or speech.
11/23 Thanksgiving (11/26)	Public Voice Project	Homework: 1. Continue developing the final project. 2. For the Public Discourse Project, revise the slides and integrated script. 3. For the Future Retirement Speech, revise the speech and prepare to record. 4. Use this lighter holiday week to make steady progress rather than starting over later.
11/30 Hanukkah (12/5)	Public Voice Project	Homework: 1. Finalize the PowerPoint and integrated script, or finalize the retirement speech script and recording. 2. If submitting a YouTube link, test the link in a private or incognito browser window. 3. Check all files, links, and submission materials before the due date.

WEEK OF	TOPIC	ASSIGNMENTS AND DUE DATES
12/7	Public Voice Project	DUE: 12/11: Public Voice Project Homework: 1. Submit the final project in Canvas. 2. For the Public Discourse Project, submit the PowerPoint and PDF with integrated script. 3. For the Future Retirement Speech, submit the script and YouTube link according to the assignment instructions. 4. Confirm that submitted files or links open correctly.

QUESTIONS ABOUT AI AND GRADING

QUESTION

Why did I get a 0 on my work?

ANSWER

If you were assigned a 0 without an explanation in the comment box it's almost certainly because you did not follow the Google Doc policy outlined in this syllabus.

QUESTION

Why can't I have AI write my work and pretend it's my own in the class? I'll be using it in the workforce so why can't I use it now?

ANSWER

Firstly, the question is, on its face, dumb. In order to demonstrate that you're a proficient writer, you actually have to write. As an instructor, I am here to guide and evaluate you, not others and certainly not robots.

But the question itself assumes that AI is a proficient writer. Is it? If by "proficient" we mean mechanically correct, then sure, AI writing is generally grammatical. But is it readable? Does it produce texts that *you* want to read? Does it make good arguments? I invite you to raise these questions throughout your study in this class.

More realistically, if AI offers anything to help your writing process, you will need to first know how to write. After all, how can you discern the good output from the bad if you don't know any better? In this class, I want to see your writing, your thinking.

QUESTION

What will happen if you suspect me of using AI for one of my assignments?

ANSWER

In terms of process, I will first evaluate and score your submission according to the rubric. Subsequently, I will gather and document evidence and file a report with SRR with my findings and they will initiate an investigation. You will receive a notice from them indicating the charges and they will undertake a fact-finding process and ultimately find one way or another for academic dishonesty. If you are found responsible for violating course and

university policies, you will receive a zero for the assignment and may fail the course.

QUESTION

Why did you refer me to Student Rights and Responsibilities for academic dishonesty?

ANSWER

First, I am duty-bound to report instances of academic misconduct to Student Rights and Responsibilities (SRR). I will honor this policy in accordance with Executive Order 1098 to ensure you receive due process.

Less formally, I can offer a few more reasons:

1. For reasons noted above, it has no place in a writing class. If you submit AI-generated content, you are, beyond complicating my ability to evaluate your performance, wasting my time.
2. SRR is building a database to better identify, record, and track this kind of content to, among other things, maintain the integrity of the academic process. I want to support this process because it contributes to things like rigor, which is directly connected to SDSU's reputation.
3. Finally, unless I am interacting with a chatbot, I dislike reading AI-generated writing. Hence, if it appears in your submissions, you are subjecting me to things I dislike.

QUESTION

How do I see feedback on my work?

QUESTIONS ABOUT CANVAS

QUESTION

How do I see feedback on my work?

ANSWER

First, written feedback on Canvas comes in two forms: comments and annotations. Comments are located under the "comments" section, and they are external to the document. If I commented on your work, it will usually be a summative remark(s) connected to my annotations, which are on the document itself. To view that, you must click on the document itself and hover your mouse over the bubbles that are present (see below). In the

case of Google Docs, they will appear as comments that you can review at will. **Note:** Do not delete my comments until after the semester concludes.

QUESTIONS ABOUT DUE DATES

QUESTION

My internet went out right when I was about to submit my homework assignment. By the time I got to the library to use their computer, I had missed the deadline for submission. Will this be a problem?

ANSWER

Sticking to due dates and times is very important in this online course. For some assignments, however, if you are a day or two late in submitting, you should be able to proceed with the course easily enough and you will not receive a grade reduction. You do not need to email me if you're within this grace period. (Note: Canvas will label your submission late; but again, if you submit within the above-mentioned timeframe, you may simply ignore the alert.)